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Google AI Studio 'Delete' is a scam: Your prompts are not deleted

by Bitu79 - Saturday September 26, 2026 at 10:38 AM

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#1

Google AI Studio's "Delete" button is misleading.

György Istókovics

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People keep misunderstanding the core issue, so let me explain it as simply as possible. Google is lying to you when you delete your chats in AI Studio.

Imagine you have a highly sensitive file on your computer. You right-click the shortcut on your desktop and delete it. Windows tells you: *"The file is permanently destroyed."* But the actual file is still sitting deep on your hard drive, fully readable.

This is EXACTLY what Google is doing with your AI prompts. Here is the 4-point proof of the scam:

1. The "Shortcut" Trick:

When you click "Permanent Delete" in AI Studio, Google does NOT delete your chat history from their servers. They only delete a tiny .json shortcut file in your Google Drive. Your actual sensitive prompts and data remain fully active on their backend. If you use a recovery tool to put the .json shortcut back, your chat instantly comes back to life. It was never deleted.

2. The Recovery Robot Confession:

The delete button throws a warning in your face: *"This item will be permanently deleted and cannot be recovered."*

But Google's own Help Center explicitly says: *"Our automated tool can help recover permanently deleted files."*

Use your brain: How can a robot recover something that is permanently destroyed? It can't. Google is openly admitting that "permanent delete" just means "hidden from the user."

3. Breaking Their Own Rules (24H TTL):

Google's official developer documentation promises that free-tier chats are automatically wiped after 24 hours. By just hiding the shortcut and secretly keeping your data active in the background

for 30+ days, they are bypassing their own security promises and violating European law (GDPR Article 17).

4. The Cover-Up and Ban:

I reported this massive privacy flaw to Google's Bug Bounty program with full forensic proof. Their response? A bot permanently banned my account within 60 seconds and labeled this fake delete button as *"Intended Behavior."*

It's not a bug. They designed it this way to hoard your data while making you feel safe.

1. A "Recovery Robot" Admission: The "Permanently Deleted" Oxymoron

I have documented how Google's official Help Center and their "File Recovery Tool" explicitly state: *"Our automated tool can help recover permanently deleted files from your Drive Trash..."*

This is a logical and technical fraud. If something is "permanently deleted," by definition, it cannot be recovered. Since their "special robot" can restore files within 25 to 60 days, then the system never actually deleted them. They just moved my data to a hidden, unnotified "retention buffer." Google is admitting in writing that their internal dictionary is a scam: to them, "permanent deletion" just means "hidden from the user's view." But under GDPR, a data controller cannot just make up their own definitions to bypass the law. "Deletion" means physical destruction, not "hiding it until our robot drags it back."

2. The Fake Buttons and Intentional Deception (Dark Patterns)

The buttons in AI Studio and Google Drive are a blatant lie. When I click "Delete permanently," the UI hits me with this warning: *"The item will be permanently deleted and cannot be recovered later. This action cannot be undone."*

Look at these two official Google statements side-by-side:

The UI (Frontend) lies to me: "It cannot be recovered later."

The Help Center (Backend) admits: "We can help recover permanently deleted files."

This isn't a "bug" or "Intended Behavior," as the CERT/CC bots tried to dismiss it. This is a textbook Deceptive Design (Dark Pattern). Their engineers intentionally wrote these lies on the UI buttons to create a false sense of security for me and other users who are sharing sensitive data.

GDPR Article 12 (Transparency) explicitly requires controllers to provide honest, clear information. If the software UI claims the opposite of the technical reality, that is a direct violation of law. When I clicked "Delete," I did so in the belief that my sensitive chat history, tokens, and prompts were being destroyed on the server instantly.

By advertising their "Recovery Robot" while their UI buttons claim "It cannot be recovered," Google has provided me with a written, self-published confession of systemic deception. No judge or data regulator can brush this off as a "good-faith mistake" because these two statements are mutually exclusive.

The whole thing is a cynical theater. They trick me into thinking I have control over my data, while in reality, the "Delete" buttons are just visual decorations on top of continuous server-side data

harvesting. They are not protecting data; they are managing a multi-billion dollar lie.

The Google "Delete" Scam: The .json file is just a pointer — your prompts are not deleted.

Let's get the technical facts straight, because Google is banking on you not understanding how their backend works. When you "delete" a chat, you are being deceived. Your prompts are NOT deleted.

The Backend Scam Explained:

The .json file you see in your Google Drive is NOT your actual data. It is merely a **pointer** — a map — that tells Google's backend server (Interactions API / Project Storage) where your real conversation is stored.

When you click "Delete permanently," Google's system performs a fraudulent act: **it only deletes the pointer (the map) from your Drive**. The actual session data, your sensitive prompts, and the context of your conversation remain fully intact and active in their backend "hot storage."

The Proof:

If the data were actually destroyed, restoring the file would be impossible. But it's not. If you use Google's official recovery tool to restore that tiny .json pointer even 48 hours later, your AI session resumes instantly in milliseconds.

Real, purged, or cold-storage data cannot resume execution in milliseconds. The fact that the session resumes immediately proves that Google never deleted your data, never restricted it, and never isolated it. They simply unlinked the visual pointer so you would think it's gone, while keeping your data active and accessible on their production servers.

The "Delete" button is a visual Placebo. Google is not executing a deletion; they are executing a scam to keep your sensitive data active while lying to you about its destruction.

"Stop acting like you're experts and look at the actual forensic data:"

To 'mitxela' & 'tylervigen':

You claim 'what law is broken' and 'cite no legal precedent'.

- **The Law:** GDPR Article 17 (Right to Erasure) and Article 12 (Transparency).
- **The Fraud:** Google guarantees in the Gemini API terms that data is purged (TTL) within 24 hours. My forensic evidence proves that simply restoring a .json pointer (which takes seconds) reconnects to the unpurged conversation history in backend 'hot storage'. If the data were actually deleted or purged, the server would return a 404/Not Found. It does not. It resumes the session. This is a direct violation of their own published API data retention policy and GDPR compliance.

To 'kylecazar':

You claim Google has the right to keep data for 'processing'.

- You are ignoring the UI. When I click 'Delete permanently,' Google tells me: *"The item will be permanently deleted and cannot be recovered later."* This is a **legal declaration** to the user. If their Terms of Service allow them to keep it for 30–55 days for 'abuse monitoring,' then the

'Delete' button is a **fraudulent UI element**. They are keeping data they promised the user was destroyed. That is not 'common UX', that is fraud.

To 'tgsovlerkhgsel':

You wonder what's inside the JSON.

- It's a pointer file that acts as a session-resume token. Opening it in a text editor shows the metadata linkage. Restoring it to the Drive Trash triggers the backend Interactions API to re-bind the live conversation state. The chat session does not resume because of the JSON file itself — it resumes because the JSON file re-authorizes access to the *still-existing backend state*. Cold-storage doesn't respond in milliseconds. This is physical proof of 'hot storage' persistence.

To the 'AI-generated' crowd:

I am a human security researcher. Attacking the writing style is the ultimate sign of intellectual cowardice. You are dismissing a CWE-459 (Incomplete Cleanup) vulnerability because you can't debunk the steps to reproduce it.

Steps to Reproduce (Try it yourself before commenting):

1. Generate an AI session.
2. Observe the .json file in Drive.
3. 'Permanently delete' the chat (User-facing guarantee: 'cannot be recovered').
4. Wait 48 hours (bypassing their 24h TTL).
5. Restore the .json pointer from Drive Trash.
6. The chat resumes instantly.

This is not an opinion. This is a reproducible technical failure. If you want to defend Google, explain how a file that is 'permanently deleted' and 'cannot be recovered' can be brought back to life in milliseconds using the vendor's own tools. You can't.

Google AI Studio: Restoring Drive JSON pointer recovers deleted chat sessions

Looking for technical and legal perspectives on data deletion architecture.

Consider the following scenario in an AI developer environment (like Google AI Studio / Gemini API):

1. In the UI, clicking "Delete" on a chat session moves the local client pointer (.json file) to the Trash, and emptying the Trash displays a message that the data is permanently destroyed.
2. However, running the platform's own file recovery tool restores the JSON pointer, and the live conversation immediately resumes directly from the server backend.

3. Furthermore, custom data retention windows (such as a 7-day TTL) are locked behind a billing/paid tier, but even after setting this, the session data can still be restored well past that timeframe.

This creates a dual dilemma:

- If the deletion and retention controls are mandatory statutory rights (e.g., GDPR Art. 12 & 17), how can modifying retention periods be restricted to paid accounts [1]?
- If the backend does not actually purge the underlying conversational objects upon deletion (allowing them to be resurrected via standard tools), on what technical or legal grounds can a provider charge enterprise customers for a custom retention service?

Is this standard session pointer decoupling, or does it cross into a failure of data destruction and false advertising?

AI Studio and Drive are directly connected: AI Studio automatically saves each chat session as a .json file into your Google Drive.

Here is the core problem: Paying customers literally pay Google to configure custom data retention policies (such as a strict 7-day TTL).

If a paying user sets a 7-day TTL, deletes a chat, and empties the trash, Google claims the data is permanently purged after 7 days. Yet on Day 25—well past the paid 7-day deadline—running Google's own Drive File Recovery tool restores the .json file, and the entire chat immediately resumes from Google's backend servers.

What are paid customers paying for then? Nothing! This proves there is zero backend TTL. The data is never actually purged from the servers, and Google's own recovery robot caught them red-handed selling a non-existent deletion feature.

Why does Google AI Studio allow resurrecting deleted chat data 25 days later using Drive recovery? <https://bf.st/images/kleissner.png>

Evidence

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